Q+A

Music, Memory and Restraint

FILMMAKER AND LYRICIST VARUN GROVER'S *KAMBAKHAT* EXPLORES THE DIGNITY OF AGEING ARTISTS WITHIN THE TIGHT BOUNDS OF A SHORT FILM



Q. What inspired your short film *Kambakhat*?

It is inspired from the real-life story of Zarina Begum who used to sing with Begum Akhtar. She had been ill for some time and people were trying to raise funds. I was in Lucknow at the fund-raising event and someone came with a request to sing on camera. The idea struck me then, about how people treat artists when they are dependent on the public for funds.

Q. You have directed a feature film and two shorts. Is the shorter format more challenging?

Yes, it is, that's why I like making short films. It is challenging as there is no space to develop the world; you dive straight into the story. Both my shorts are set in a single space, the first one in a film theatre, and this one in a hospital.

Q. As a filmmaker, what is the one aspect of your films you want the audience to take away?

I want people to feel a sense of calm. I want them to feel that the world can slow down and that we don't need to chase things all the time—I have tried to do this in every film I've written till now, from *Masaan* to *Superboys of Malegaon*, to, my own film, *All India Rank*.

Q. What's next for you?

I've written dialogues for an animated film by Abhimanyu Bhattacharya called *Heirloom*. It will hopefully come out next year. I've made a short animation film called *Hari Patang Pe Hara Patanga*, based on a long poem I had written. I have co-directed it with Allen Shaw, an animator based in Berlin. We are sending it to film festivals.

—with Deepali Dhingra